

Chapter 7

The Ring

Saturday evening arrived quietly.

For the first time in what felt like weeks, Elara had nowhere she needed to be.

No meetings.

No presentations.

No files waiting on her desk.

And yet...

her mind refused to rest.

She sat near the window in her room, watching the evening sky slowly darken.

Her phone lay beside her.

For a moment, she looked at the unknown number again.

The conversation was still empty.

She had typed something.

Deleted it.

Typed again.

Deleted that too.

She had never even seen the man's face.

So why was she thinking about him?

Maybe it had been the fragrance.

Maybe the voice.

Maybe nothing at all.

She locked her phone.

"Enough."

A knock came at the door.

Her mother stepped inside.

"Elara, we're leaving soon."

"For where?"

Her mother gave her a look.

"Ethan's house."

Elara remembered.

"Oh."

"Go get ready."

Elara smiled faintly.

"Okay."

By the time they arrived, the sky had turned completely dark.

Warm lights surrounded Ethan's family home, making it look peaceful against the cool evening air.

The front door opened before they even knocked.

Ethan's mother greeted them with a smile.

"I'm so glad you all came."

Elara's mother hugged her warmly.

"It's been too long."

Behind them, Ethan appeared.

He looked at Elara and smiled.

"You actually came."

She raised an eyebrow.

"Why wouldn't I?"

"I wasn't sure."

"That's rude."

He laughed.

"I meant you usually find some excuse to disappear."

"I've been busy."

"I know."

His voice softened slightly.

"And you've been working too much."

Elara gave him a small smile.

"I'm trying to get used to everything."

"You will."

He stepped aside to let them in.

Their fathers were already talking in the living room.

The conversation quickly turned toward business.

Northbridge.

A new investment.

A development project.

An upcoming meeting.

Elara listened quietly for a while.

Her father noticed.

"Come sit with us."

She joined them.

Ethan's father smiled.

"How was your first month ?"

"Busy."

"That's a good sign."

He leaned back.

"An empty calendar is more dangerous for a new executive than a difficult one."

Elara smiled.

"Why?"

"Because difficulty forces you to learn."

Her father nodded.

"He's right."

The conversation continued.

Elara asked a few questions about an upcoming project, and soon the discussion became more serious.

She found herself genuinely interested.

Ethan watched her from across the room.

Not constantly.

Not obviously.

Just enough to notice when she spoke.

When she disagreed.

When she smiled.

At one point, Elara made a small mistake while explaining a number.

Ethan corrected it before anyone else could.

She looked at him.

"I knew that."

"Of course you did."

She gave him an annoyed look.

He smiled.

Their fathers laughed.

"Some things never change," Ethan's father said.

"What things?" Elara asked.

"You two have been arguing since you were children."

Ethan laughed.

"She started it."

"I did not."

"You definitely did."

The evening became lighter.

Dinner was soon served.

Everyone gathered around the table.

There were stories about business.

Stories about old friendships.

And eventually...

stories about college.

Daniel's name came up more than once.

Then Ava.

France.

Her new work.

Her upcoming wedding.

Everyone had something to say.

For a while...

Noah's name didn't come up.

Then Ethan's mother quietly mentioned an old college trip.

"Do you remember how you all used to disappear together?"

Elara smiled.

"We weren't disappearing."

"You were skipping lectures."

Ethan laughed.

"She still says she was forced."

"I was."

Everyone laughed.

For a moment...

the room felt warm.

Familiar.

Almost like nothing had ever gone wrong.

After dinner, the adults moved back into the living room.

Elara stayed behind for a moment, helping Ethan's mother.

When she finally walked into the hallway...

her eyes caught something sitting on a small side table.

A ring.

Simple.

Dark silver.

She slowed down.

Something about it immediately caught her attention.

She stepped closer.

Her expression changed.

She knew that ring.

Not from here.

From Noah.

She had seen it before.

More than once.

Once on Noah's desk.

Another time in her hand while they were talking after class.

Elara had asked her about it.

Noah had only smiled and changed the subject.

She had never understood why.

Now...

the same ring was sitting quietly on Ethan's side table.

Elara stared at it.

"Why is that here?"

Her voice was barely a whisper.

"Elara?"

She turned quickly.

Ethan stood at the end of the hallway.

His eyes moved from her to the ring.

For a second...

he said nothing.

Then he walked over.

"What are you doing?"

She pointed toward the table.

"That ring..."

Ethan looked at it.

"What's wrong with it?"

"I've seen it before."

"Where?"

Elara hesitated.

"With Noah."

Something changed in Ethan's face.

Only for a moment.

Then it was gone.

He picked up the ring.

"You probably remember it from college."

Elara looked at him.

"No..."

She wasn't sure why, but something about his answer didn't feel complete.

"I've definitely seen this one."

Ethan slipped the ring into his pocket.

"It's old."

"Where did you get it?"

He looked at her for a second.

Then smiled.

"Some things are better left in the past."

The words were casual.

Almost too casual.

Elara didn't reply.

Ethan walked back toward the living room.

She remained in the hallway for a few seconds.

Watching him.

Then her eyes dropped to the empty spot on the side table.

The ring was gone.

But the question remained.

Why had Noah had it?

And why did Ethan?

Later that night...

Elara sat in the back seat as her parents drove home.

The city lights passed quietly outside the window.

She rested her head against the glass.

Her thoughts moved between two things.

The unknown man from the library.

And the ring she had seen at Ethan's house.

One had a familiar voice.

The other carried an old memory.

Neither made sense.

She closed her eyes.

Somewhere in the dark...

the pieces were beginning to connect.

But she still couldn't see the picture.